

In 2015, we were both at the World Cup. I got knocked out early, and he [Anish] was still in the tournament. I didn't know him well, but we met through mutual friends. I asked him if he needed a coach since I had already been eliminated, and he said no. So our relationship started with rejection [laughs].

Later, when he qualified for the Candidates, he reached out to me for an online training session. We worked together for a week, and he liked the energy and vibe. That led to him inviting me to the Netherlands for training.

We ended up working together on and off for two years across various events. The best thing was how well our energy matched. He's funny, and I can take his jokes. He can take mine too. We're also the same age, which helped. Plus, he has a wonderful family and a very homely environment.

Despite this, you didn't include Anish in your Candidates' preparation team...

I wanted to transition to a more aggressive style of play, and his style didn't align with that. So although he's a great friend, from a technical standpoint, it wasn't the right fit. It was a pragmatic decision.

In a recent interview, you mentioned considering retirement or moving to something less stressful. Is that thought still on your mind?

Yes, it is. Look at Magnus Carlsen — he's not playing classical tournaments now, but he still plays rapid and blitz because of his deep love for chess.

I also have a passion for chess — otherwise, I wouldn't have played for 23-24 years. But I have other interests too. I'm very tech-savvy. I love technology, I read about it constantly, and I've even tried to

build things myself. I was learning to code at one point and wanted to create software. Now, with AI, I want to explore what's possible.

I'm a tech nerd, and I'm also Gujarati — so business is in my DNA! Maybe I'll explore tech or business or even combine the two.

Chess is an inherently stressful game, especially at the highest level. How do you manage that stress?

Any professional sportsperson experiences stress, anxiety, and fear. The best thing about sports is that it provides quick feedback. A normal person may not get that feedback as immediately, but in sports, there's always something at stake.

It's like being thrown into a cage — that's when your instincts kick in, and you realise where you stand. Chess has given me immense self-awareness and has been my greatest catalyst for spiritual growth because it has helped me understand myself better.

Is that what led you to meditation, or was it something you always practised?

I was always inclined towards spirituality but didn't know which path to take. In 2019, I came across a video and a book by my Guru, Om Swamiji. I later visited his ashram in Himachal Pradesh. That's when I found a mentor for life.

He guided me in working on myself, and meditation became an integral part of my routine. All my success in chess has been, in some way, because of his guidance.

Another significant factor is, of course, your fiancée, Nidhi Kataria. How does she support you through the process?

I am blessed to have found someone like Nidhi (facing page), who is extremely supportive. She

was new to the chess world but made an effort to learn the game. She tried following my matches but couldn't understand much, so she would rely on the engine bar to figure out what was happening.

She is very soft-spoken and gentle. Having a supportive partner who truly understands you is often underrated. Chess players go through a lot emotionally, and she has been my rock — grounding me and bringing me back to the good side of life.

What are your chess plans for 2025?

I won't be competing in the Candidates cycle, as the qualification process is quite tough. Instead, I will focus on the World Cup and the Grand Swiss for direct qualification. The game is shifting towards rapid and blitz formats, and adapting to that change is essential.

What are your thoughts on freestyle chess? Do you see a future where it replaces traditional formats?

It's possible, but it doesn't have to be a replacement — it's like saying if you have paneer, you can't have tofu. Both can exist independently. It's a welcome addition but doesn't need to take over.

It's interesting to play, but as a spectator, I'm still getting used to it. The positions aren't what you typically see in a chess game, so it can sometimes be hard to follow.

However, as a player, it's a lot more fun. One of the challenges in modern chess is the sheer amount of preparation required, with computers making it harder to be creative in openings. Freestyle chess offers so many possibilities, forcing players to rely more on their thinking. There's less preparation and more on-the-board play, much like in the old days.

